



DRIVE

The Surprising Truth about What Motivates Us

By Daniel H. Pink

The Big “So What”



By truly understanding human motivation and creating the right environment, organizations can help people to discover their innate drive, to become naturally more productive, fulfilled and happy.

Introduction



There’s a gap between what we know about motivation and how businesses and society currently operate. Most of our systems are built around carrot-and-stick and external motivation, which are not always effective and may sometimes backfire. To maximize productivity and motivation in the 21st century work, we need to upgrade our approach to tap on and increase intrinsic motivation, with 3 elements: autonomy, mastery and purpose.

Developing a new Operating System

Like computers, societies have operating systems – our laws and socioeconomic frameworks are built on assumptions of how things work and how humans behave. Pink traces how these underlying assumptions (and consequently society’s operating systems) have evolved over time:



Motivation 1.0 – Biological needs

This system assumes that humans are driven by our biological and survival needs, i.e. food, security and sex.

KEY QUOTES

“Societies also have operating systems... And much of our societal operating system consists of a set of assumptions about human behaviour.”

Carrot-and-stick approach

“For as long as any of us can remember, we’ve configured our organizations and constructed our lives around its bedrock assumption: The way to improve performance, increase productivity, and encourage excellence is to reward the good and punish the bad”.



Motivation 2.0 – Extrinsic Rewards & Punishments

This system assumes that humans seek rewards and avoid punishments, in addition to satisfying our biological needs. It is still deeply embedded in most aspects of our lives today. Pink points out that Motivation 2.0 works, but not all the time, because of 3 areas of incompatibility:

- **How we organize what we do:** Pink uses the growing trend of opensourcing to illustrate how people are changing the way we organize our efforts, driven by the intrinsic satisfaction of mastering a challenge, and the desire to contribute to the community. In short, traditional businesses are “profit maximizers”, but there is a growing number of businesses that are “purpose maximizers”.
- **How we think about what we do:** The assumption that we are wealth-maximizers is flawed, because we do not consistently seek to maximize wealth, nor do we always respond rationally to extrinsic incentives.
- **How we do what we do:** Motivation 2.0 is based on the belief that people need extrinsic rewards and close supervision because they do not enjoy their work. However, many jobs have become more interesting and self-directed. Moreover, external motivation may work for algorithmic tasks that follow fixed rules and instructions, but are counter-productive for heuristic tasks that require creativity to solve novel problems.



Motivation 3.0 - Intrinsic Motivation

Pink recommends a full upgrade to this operating system for the 21st century. This system is built on the assumption that, besides biological urges and extrinsic motivation, humans also have a desire to learn, to create, and to make the world a better place. In short, it recognizes the “third drive” or intrinsic motivation, which includes 3 elements:

KEY QUOTES

“Motivation 2.0...doesn’t mesh with the way many new business models are organizing what we do – because we’re intrinsically motivated purpose maximizers, not only extrinsically motivated profit maximizers.”

“Economists are finally realizing that we’re fullfledged human beings, not single-minded economic robots.”

“For growing numbers of people, work is often creative, interesting, and self-directed rather than unrelentingly routine, boring, and other-directed.”

Motivation 3.0

“The science shows that the secret to high performance...(is) our deep-seated desire to direct our own lives, to extend and expand our abilities, and to make a contribution.”



- **Autonomy:** The desire to direct our own lives
- **Mastery:** The desire to get better and better at something that matters
- **Purpose:** The desire to serve something larger than ourselves

From Motivation 2.0 to Motivation 3.0



The Starting Point: Baseline rewards

“Baseline rewards” (like salary, some perks and benefits) are prerequisites to motivation, i.e. **people must minimally be paid a fair and equitable amount**. Without a healthy baseline, there is no motivation to speak of. **However, beyond that baseline, money or carrots and sticks can actually dampen rather than increase motivation.**



Why Carrots & Sticks Can Backfire

- Extrinsic rewards, especially contingent rewards or “if-then” rewards, may unintentionally **extinguish intrinsic motivation** and hence decrease performance and creativity. Extrinsic rewards may still work in the short run, but they tend to cause “considerable long-term damage”
- Empirically, it is proven that introducing or increasing **incentives does not always improve performance, and may in fact reduce performance** (especially if they are contingent incentives).
- Rewards tend to narrow our focus, which is helpful to get us to focus and run faster on a fixed path, or to handle algorithmic tasks. They however tend to **hinder right-brain thinking or creative solutions**.
- People sometimes do things for intrinsic satisfaction or “feelings that money can’t buy” – introducing rewards may **extinguish the nobility and interesting aspects and reduce the desired behaviours**.

KEY QUOTES

“Baseline rewards”

The best use of money as a motivator is to pay people enough to take the issue of money off the table.”

Extrinsic Motivation

“Sometimes these motivators work. Often they don’t. And many times, they inflict collateral damage”.

“Over and over again, (researchers) discovered that extrinsic rewards – in particular, contingent, expected, “if-then” rewards – snuffed out the third drive.”

- Rewards may end up **encouraging undesired behaviours and attitudes** including unethical behaviour, addiction, short-term thinking, cheating and short-cuts.



When and How to Use Carrots & Sticks

Extrinsic rewards do have their uses. Specifically:



Routine tasks: People performing **routine, dull tasks** that involve only mechanical skills have little or no intrinsic motivation to be lost. In such cases, **you can use rewards to boost performance, with the following approach:**

- Explain why the task is necessary, so you provide meaning for an otherwise-boring task.
- Acknowledge that the task is boring, as an act of empathy
- Provide autonomy, and give people some freedom over how they complete the task



Now-then rewards: For non-routine conceptual tasks, offer “now then” rewards instead of “if-then” rewards, **i.e. offer rewards as a surprise or bonus after the task is completed.**

This is assuming the basic compensation and the 3 elements of autonomy, mastery and larger purpose are already in place. Ideally, these rewards should follow 2 additional guidelines:

- Use **non-tangible rewards** like praise and positive feedback rather than just cash and physical trophies.
- Provide **specific feedback**, focusing on their effort and strategy (rather than must the results)



Self-Determination Theory (SDT)

To stay relevant, businesses can update their approach to motivation, using the self-determination theory (SDT). **According to SDT, human beings have an innate drive to be autonomous, self-determined and connected; if we focus on creating environments where this drive can be expressed,**

KEY QUOTES

“Mixing rewards with inherently interesting, creative or noble tasks deploying them without understanding the peculiar science of motivation, is a very dangerous game.”

“Greatness and nearsightedness are incompatible. Meaningful achievement depends on lifting one’s sights and pushing toward the horizon.”

people are more productive, fulfilled and happy.

Organisations should focus on these drives when managing their human capital, by creating settings which focus on our innate need to direct our own lives (autonomy), to learn and create new things (mastery), and to do better by ourselves and our world (purpose).



Moving from Type X to Type I Behaviours

Pink classifies human behaviour into 2 main types - **Type X** (primarily motivated by extrinsic factors) and **Type I** (fuelled more by the inherent satisfaction of an activity). Generally, Type I behaviour generates better results, health, and overall well-being. Hence, Pink advocates that **we move ourselves (and our colleagues) gradually from Type X to Type I**. In particular:

- In the long run, Type I's almost always outperform Type X's, and they enjoy greater physical and mental well-being.
- For Type X's the main motivator is external rewards (e.g. money and recognition); any deeper satisfaction is welcome but secondary. For Type I's, the main motivator is the freedom, challenge, and purpose of the task; any external reward are welcome but only as a bonus.
- Type I behaviour traits are not fixed, so any Type X can become a Type I.

The Three Elements of Motivation 3.0



1. Autonomy

Autonomy essentially means acting with choice. It is different from independence, as you can choose to work interdependently with others. Having a sense of autonomy **can produce significant improvements in performance and attitude**. A Cornell University study found that autonomy-oriented businesses grew 4 times faster and had 3 times lower turnover than control-oriented firms.

KEY QUOTES

*"We're designed to be Type I...
If we update the environments
we're in... we can return ourselves
and our colleagues
to our natural state."*

*"This era doesn't call for
better management. It calls
for a renaissance of selfdirection."*

*"Autonomy... is different from
independence. It means
acting with choice - which
means we can be both
autonomous and happily
interdependent with others."*

Based on the SDT, we are naturally Type Is (self-directed and autonomous). However, most of us have been conditioned to adhere to outdated concepts of management, which assumes that those being managed need prodding to move forward, and need to be given direction to stay on-track. Even the concept of empowerment is built on the pretext that the organization holds the power and is “generously” sharing it with employees. **Given the right environment, we will return to our natural Type I state.**

One such environment is the **Results-Only Work Environment (ROWE)** conceptualized by Cali Ressler and Jody Thompson. **Here, people don't have fixed work schedules; they are free to do their work where, when and however they wish, so long as they get their work done.** People are treated as partners, not resources, and hence need to direct their own lives.

Encouraging autonomy doesn't mean people need not be accountable for their work. On the contrary, **Motivation 3.0 assumes people want to be accountable**, and the way to encourage Type I behaviour and enable superior performance is to **give autonomy over 4 essential areas:**

- **Task (What they do)**
- **Time (When they do it)**
- **Team (Who they do it with)**
- **Technique (How they do it)**



2. Mastery

Mastery means becoming better at something that matters, and this can only be achieved through deep engagement or flow. When “in flow”, we are typically performing at a notch or two beyond our current abilities, which stretches our body and mind to produces a level of focus and satisfaction that extremely rewarding. We lose ourselves (positively) in what we are doing.

While flow is essential to mastery, it happens in a moment, and hence doesn't guarantee mastery, which happens over time and with repeated practice. **There are 3 laws that govern mastery:**

KEY QUOTES

“Control leads to compliance; autonomy leads to engagement.”

“In flow, people lived so deeply in the moment, and felt so utterly in control, that their sense of time and even self melted away.”

“Flow is essential to mastery. But flow doesn't guarantee mastery – because the two concepts operate on different horizons of time. One happens in a moment; the other unfolds over months, years and sometimes decades.”

- **Mastery is a mindset:** Our beliefs shape what we achieve. Type X behaviour holds an “entity theory of intelligence”, i.e. the belief that our abilities are finite, and they value performance over learning goals. Type I behaviour holds the “**incremental theory of intelligence**”, i.e. the belief that **our intelligence and capabilities can improve infinitely**, and learning goals are prized over performance goals. “Begin with one mindset, and mastery is impossible. Begin with the other, and it can be inevitable.”
- **Mastery is pain:** **Mastery requires grit, all-out effort, and deliberate practice over a long period of time.** It often involves periods of hard work and effort with little improvement, and doing what you love to do even when you don’t feel like doing them.
- **Mastery is an asymptote:** An asymptote is a straight line that a curve approaches but never reaches. **You can approach and get extremely close to mastery, but it is impossible to fully realize it.** This can be frustrating, but also alluring at the same time.

To enrich and motivate people, organizations can create conditions for people to make progress, then highlight, recognize and celebrate that progress.



3. Purpose

Purpose is about linking your desires to a cause that’s bigger than yourself. It provides a context for autonomy and mastery. Motivated, productive and fulfilled people typically work towards a higher purpose beyond their self-interest. The main difference between Motivation 2.0 and 3.0 is that the latter places **equal emphasis on profit-maximization and purpose-maximization**, not just focus on profit-maximization alone.

There are 3 ways to express “purpose motives” in the organization:

- **Goals:** Place purpose as the priority, and use profits as a catalyst rather than the key objective.

KEY QUOTES

“What people believe shapes what people achieve.”

“Mastery hurts. Sometimes – many times – it’s not much fun... It’s grueling, to be sure. But that’s not the problem; that’s the solution.”

“The joy is in the pursuit more than the realization. In the end, mastery attracts precisely because mastery eludes.”

“Autonomous people working toward mastery perform at very high levels. But those who do so in the service of some greater objective can achieve even more.”

“Humanize what people say and you may well humanize what they do.”

- **Words:** Choose words that are humanized and lean towards a purpose beyond self-interest. Focus on “why” rather than “how”.
- **Policies:** Allow people to pursue purpose on their own terms.

KEY QUOTES

*“People at work are
thirsting for context...
a powerful way to provide
that context is to spend
a little less time telling how
and a little more time
showing why.”*